

graduate in the US. When Garrett Anderson was denied access to medical school on account of her gender, she was undeterred. She discovered a loophole; a London guild called the Worshipful Society of Apothecaries could still license physicians, and its charter did not permit them to bar women. In 1865, she passed their examinations and earned the right to practice medicine. Garrett Anderson went on to have a distinguished medical career, and paved the way for countless other women.

As many medical colleges would only accept men, specialist institutions for women began to be set up, such as the New England Female Medical College, established in Boston in 1848. This, and similar institutions such as the London School of Medicine for Women (founded in 1874), allowed women to earn medical degrees. Around the same time, the training of nurses was modernized and professionalized. An influential pioneer in this endeavor was the English nurse Florence Nightingale who, after serving in the Crimean War (1854–1856), established a nursing school at St. Thomas' Hospital, London, in 1860.

Women break through

Despite these advances, the barriers faced by women in medicine were numerous, and numbers in the field remained low. Even those who had completed training were rejected by the male medical establishment, and consequently, many female physicians set up their own clinics. World War I proved to be a watershed; the need for doctors and the death of so many men led to more universities opening their doors to women to train in medicine. As a result women became more active in medical research; in 1947 the Czech-American scientist Gerty Cori became the first woman to win the Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine. The 1970s saw another profound change as anti-discrimination laws in many countries led to more women enrolling at medical colleges. In most Western countries in the world, there are now roughly equal numbers of men and women training to be doctors.



▲ Lady with the lamp

This Turkish lantern was used by Crimean war nurses and possibly by Florence Nightingale herself in the 1850s. The nurses' workload was huge; at one point less than 100 nurses had 10,000 men under their care.

PROFILES

PRACTITIONERS

Jacqueline Felice de Almania (c. 1322) highlights the suspicion that women practicing medicine faced. Born to a Jewish family in Florence, she moved to Paris where she worked as a physician and performed surgery. In 1322 she was tried for practicing unlawfully. In spite of the court hearing testimonials of her ability as a doctor, she and three other female doctors were banned from medicine.

Tan Yunxian (1461–1554) was a Chinese physician who learned her skills from her grandparents. Chinese women at the time could not serve apprenticeships with doctors, but Tan passed the jinshi exam despite being humiliated and insulted by her examiners. Tan treated women from the humble to the elite. In 1511, Tan wrote a book, *Sayings of a Female Doctor*, describing her career as a physician.

James Barry (c. 1789–1865) was born Margaret Bulkley in Ireland but, disguised as a man, she enrolled at Edinburgh University to study medicine. She qualified as a surgeon in 1813, then joined the British Army, serving overseas. Barry was a skilled surgeon and promoter of sanitation, who rose to the rank of Inspector General of Hospitals. Barry retired in 1859, having spent her entire medical career living and working as a man.

Elizabeth Blackwell (1821–1910) was born in England but emigrated to the US in 1832. In 1849 she graduated top of her class at medical college—the first woman in America to earn a degree in medicine. In 1853, she opened a dispensary in New York, and during the Civil War trained nurses. She returned to England in 1869, where she had her own practice and taught medicine.

Rebecca Lee Crumpler (1831–1895) worked as a nurse for eight years before enrolling in medical college in Boston in 1860. Four years later, she was the first African American woman to receive a medical degree. She moved to Virginia in 1865, where she provided medical care to freed slaves. Four years later she returned to Boston where she continued to practice medicine.

Kadambini Ganguly (1861–1923) was born in Bhagalpur, northern India. In 1883, she became the first of two Indian women to gain a university degree. In 1886, she graduated from medical college in Kolkata—the same year another Indian woman, Anandi Gopal Joshi, graduated with a medical degree in the US.